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Course: 21LEM202T - Universal Human Values - II

Unit – 4 : Session – 3 | Classifying Reality into the Four Orders

Part C — Long-Answer Questions (Solutions)

1. Q1. WHY four categories: nature's innumerable units can be completely and non-overlappingly classified into these four orders on the basis of their ACTIVITY and INNATENESS — (1) units with only composition/decomposition (material), (2) those that additionally respire (pranic), (3) those that additionally select/taste in a self (animal), (4) those that can know, assume, recognise, fulfil, think (human). HOW to classify: ask 'what activities does this unit perform?' A FISH: it has a body (composition, respiration) AND selects/tastes (chooses food, moves toward bait) but cannot know or think in the human sense -> ANIMAL ORDER. An INSECT (mosquito/ant): same reasoning — selects/tastes -> ANIMAL ORDER. A mango TREE: composes, respires, grows, but does not select/taste -> PRANIC ORDER. A stone: only composes/decomposes -> MATERIAL ORDER.
2. Q2. THE EARTHQUAKE OBJECTION: 'If nature is harmony, why do earthquakes and floods kill?' — Answer: an earthquake is an activity of the MATERIAL order following its own definite, physio-chemical laws (tectonic movement); it is neither good nor bad in itself. The suffering arises (a) at the level of physio-chemical activity of nature doing what it must, (b) amplified by OUR choices — building on fault lines without understanding, destroying the forests and wetlands that absorbed shocks, and (c) experienced as UNHAPPINESS in the SELF through our unverified assumptions ('nature is against us'). Participation in the LARGER ORDER means: understand nature's laws, align our systems with them (siting, design, preparedness), and protect the orders that buffer us. Nature is not cruel; our ignorance makes us vulnerable.
3. Q3. THE SURVIVAL-OF-THE-FITTEST OBJECTION: 'Nature is a brutal struggle; harmony is romantic.' — Answer: for MATERIAL and PRANIC units, 'survival' is simply EXISTENCE — continuing in their order (a plant lives, seeds, dies, enriches soil). What looks like 'struggle' (predator eating prey) is PARTICIPATION in the cyclical food chain — the deer enriches the tiger, the tiger keeps the herd healthy, the carcass feeds the soil. The FEELING of struggle — fear, hatred, domination — exists only in the HUMAN IMAGINATION projected onto nature. Nature runs on mutual fulfilment; it is the human being, assuming scarcity and competition, who converts participation into struggle.
4. Q4. Applying the classification to my surroundings: my water bottle (material — only composition), the campus trees (pranic — respiration added), the street dogs and crows (animal — selection/tasting added), my classmates and I (human — knowing/assuming added). This simple lens changes perception: instead of seeing 'things to use', I see orders in which I am a participant — the bottle's plastic must return to a cycle, the tree deserves protection, the dog deserves care, and the humans deserve relationship.